



Aragonite

△ Crystals of aragonite in a rock groundmass

Aragonite occurs in rocks in the same way as other minerals, but it is also produced by certain biological processes – the shells of many marine molluscs, as well as corals and pearls, are composed mainly of aragonite. Like all carbonates, it is soft, fragile, and very difficult to facet, with transparent crystals only rarely faceted for collectors. Facet-quality crystals come from the Czech Republic, and there are superb cave formations in Mexico, but its type locality is Molina de Aragón in Spain after which it is named, following its discovery there in 1797.

Specification

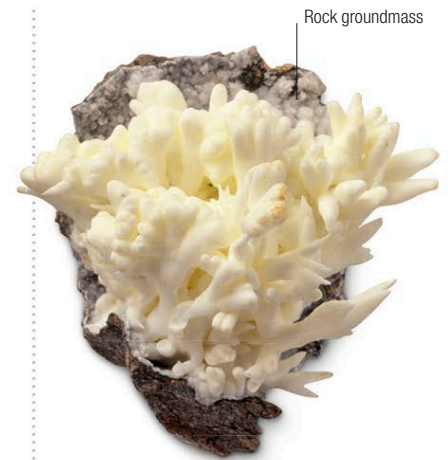
Chemical name Calcium carbonate | **Formula** CaCO_3
Colours Colourless, white, grey, yellowish, reddish, green
Structure Orthorhombic | **Hardness** 3.5–4 | **SG** 2.9
RI 1.53 – 1.68 | **Lustre** Vitreous inclining to resinous
Streak White | **Locations** Spain, Italy, China



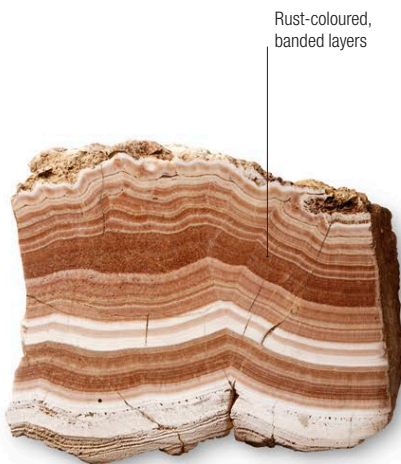
Spanish aragonite | Rough | The purple aragonite from the classic Spanish locality forms pseudo-hexagonal prisms, a cluster of which is shown here.



Aragonite sputnik | Rough | Mineral collectors sometimes refer to these radiating groups of orange pseudo-hexagonal aragonite crystals as "sputniks" or star clusters. The clusters are formed from multiple twin crystals.



Flos Ferri | Rough | Aragonite sometimes forms in tree-like crystal groups. Known as Flos Ferri, or "popcorn" aragonite, it is brittle and extremely fragile.



Aragonite slice | Cut | Layered aragonite forms in caves as stalactites. It is polished as cabochons, used as jewellery mounting or, if large enough, as wall panelling.



Orange aragonite | Colour variety | This naturally smoothed aragonite pebble displays a particularly bright orange colouring and faint pale layering.



Turquoise cabochon | Cut | Aragonite layered and banded together in mixed colours is sometimes cut *en cabochon*, as seen in this turquoise, pear-shaped stone.



Monkey ornament | Carved | Aragonite is soft and easily carved, so when it is compact enough, ornaments such as this brown monkey can be produced.